

bourhood. It was an opportunity lost.

What is sad is that he has done much better in the past and with much more panache. At an earlier press conference in February 2006 when asked about L.K. Advani's attack on him as India's weakest prime minister, he said wryly, "the proof of the pudding is in the eating." At another occasion, he used the press conference as a platform to announce the Sixth Pay Commission. Interestingly, it was a pre-planned announcement, with Sanjaya Baru, the prime minister's then media adviser, having first discussed the agenda with Manmohan, decided on possible headlines, and then ensured that it went according to script. Orchestrating such "spontaneous" announcements incidentally is the role of the prime minister's media team and this was perfected to a fine art during Indira Gandhi's tenure where she herself took the initiative in her opening remarks.

Few will forget that it was in response to a question from a Pakistani journalist that Rajiv Gandhi sacked the then foreign secretary A.P. Venkateshwaran in full public view. Where he lagged on policy, he made up with dimpled charm. When asked by a reporter how he would compete with his mother who had come to power on the promise of "a government that works", Rajiv smiled and said, "I'll give you a government that works faster." A.B. Vajpayee was another charmer who had mastered the fine art of a sound-bite, albeit at slow speed. His "neither tired nor retired" line was one such gem. But instead of national press meets he preferred to hold a press conference every time he visited his constituency, Lucknow. In fact, few apart from the Nehru-Gandhis have mastered this art. Morarji Desai during his two-and-a-half-years tenure held a press conference every new year. Unfortunately, he was so excited that he decided to make this into a family outing getting his son Kanti Desai to accompany him. The questions too ranged from personal—his urine therapy—to global. But as journalist Inder Malhotra recalled in a recent inter-

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THE CABINET WAS NOT INVITED AS THE PRESENCE OF SOME CONTROVERSIAL COLLEAGUES WOULD HAVE EMBARRASSED HIM

17 QUESTIONS ON THE NAXAL MENACE ELICITED SIMILAR RHETORICAL ANSWERS, PROVING THAT THE EXERCISE WAS AIMED AT CONCEALING MORE THAN REVEALING.

view, it was Jawaharlal Nehru's last press conference that was the most ironic. Asked if he would nominate a successor in his lifetime Nehru retorted, "My lifetime is not ending that soon." He died four days after.

Used properly, a press conference can be the finest accessory for any smart ruler. In most evolved democracies, the rulers meet up with the press at frequent intervals. Despite his plummeting ratings during the latter half of his second term, George W. Bush regularly met up with the White House Press Corps. For the public at large, the sight of a prime minister or President being grilled during a national news conference reflects a measure of accountability. If the prime minister is savvy enough he can use this medium to accessorise his image.

Sometimes Manmohan uses gentle humour to deflect uncomfortable questions. When it was pointed out that he got constant advice from two women, his wife Gursharan Kaur and the Congress chief, he conceded the point with a smile and added, "But both of them deal with different subjects." That is quintessential Manmohan. Unfortunately this was a solitary in-

stance when he took a break from bland pronouncements. So what could have been prime time viewing became a flop show. Certainly not the review the prime minister was hoping for. In retrospect Manmohan would have been much better if he had not held the press conference as this exercise concealed more than it revealed. There were 17 questions on Naxalism—all of which elicited the same, formula answer. In a cabinet form of government, the prime minister is said to be the first among equals. The Prime Minister's Office had decided that it would invite all cabinet ministers to the press conference. But with most of the senior ministers from the alliance partners travelling abroad and the ones left behind—like A. Raja and Mamata Banerjee—not exactly the kind in whose company he would have revelled, Manmohan quietly asked all his senior colleagues not to be present. The only cabinet minister present was Information and Broadcasting Minister Ambika Soni who is now tasked with finding out how the Doordarshan live telecast blanked for about five minutes.

Perhaps, the next time, the prime minister should just let his work speak for itself. ■